

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Caste Discrimination: Gandhi and Ambedkar - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

CASTE DISCRIMINATION: GANDHI AND AMBEDKAR		
PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL • PAPER II • SOCIO-POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY • TOPIC 10		
00 The central question and conceptual grammar CENTRAL QUESTION -> how does birth-based hierarchy reproduce itself, and how do Gandhi and Ambedkar differently seek its transformation? VARNA != JATI != CASTE != UNTOUCHABILITY varna: textual classification jati: local endogamous	01 Reproduction: endogamy to graded inequality endogamy -> inherited membership -> hereditary status -> occupational closure + purity/pollution + sanction -> division of labourers -> graded inequality -> fractured solidarity and restricted free association TRAP -> caste is not merely work division, class or prejudice.	02 Caste in democracy and the body politic universal franchise -> political voice, representation, bargaining caste power -> patronage, candidate selection, social blocs ASSERTION for equal citizenship != DEFENCE of hereditary supremacy
03 Gandhi's staged position EARLIER -> idealised varna: hereditary duty, no asserted superiority CAMPAIGN -> untouchability condemned; temple entry and common service LATER -> increasingly critical of birth barriers; inter-caste marriage	04 Gandhian moral reform: argument and method equal spiritual worth -> untouchability violates truth and ahimsa -> privileged caste responsibility, repentance, self-purification -> satyagraha + constructive programme + reinterpretation	05 Ambedkar's caste diagnosis Castes in India (1916) -> endogamy closes the marriage circle closed circle -> caste reproduction -> status hierarchy graded inequality -> each level has stake in distinction below RESULT -> caste is anti-social and weakens public
06 Annihilation rather than adjustment Annihilation of Caste (1936) -> isolated reform leaves sanction intact caste-sanctioning authority + endogamy + power must be confronted inter-caste marriage attacks closure; education/organisation build agency	07 Ambedkar's social-democratic programme rights + remedies -> protected action representation -> autonomous political voice constitutional morality -> civic norms above inherited authority liberty + equality + fraternity -> social democracy conversion (1956) -> ethical reconstruction, not mere	08 The Gandhi-Ambedkar matrix TARGET: Gandhi untouchability/late barriers Ambedkar caste itself ROOT: corrupted conscience endogamy, sanction, closure, power AGENT: reformed society autonomous oppressed organisation
09 Poona Pact and secular democracy Communal Award (1932) -> separate electoral arrangements Poona Pact (1932) -> joint electorate + reserved seats + primary-election mechanism Gandhi: feared lasting separation Ambedkar: feared dependent representatives	10 Safeguards, affirmative action and legal-status discipline Article 17 -> constitutional rule abolishing untouchability 1989 Act, in force 1990 -> enacted protective penal statute grounds -> compensatory distributive representational anti-domination	11 PYQ answer spine and qualified conclusion DEFINE -> name the exact caste mechanism or thinker-axis DISTINGUISH -> varna/jati/caste; reform/annihilation; law/social change ARGUE -> named anchor -> analysis -> objection/reply -> residual limit

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

AUTHORED MCQ AND REMEDIATION BANK

Q1. Which distinction is accurate?

- A. Varna is not identical with lived jati.
- B. Jati and untouchability are synonyms.
- C. Caste means only occupation.
- D. Untouchability is the whole caste system.

Answer: A. Varna is not identical with lived jati.

Explanation: Varna is a textual classification while jati is a lived birth-based group.

Trap/remediation: Do not collapse the four terms.

Q2. Ambedkar's 'division of labourers' chiefly means:

- A. work is always unjustly divided
- B. workers are fixed and ranked by birth
- C. all occupations are identical
- D. labour has no social value

Answer: B. workers are fixed and ranked by birth

Explanation: The point is hereditary ranking and closure of persons.

Trap/remediation: Do not substitute a generic anti-work claim.

Q3. Graded inequality impedes solidarity because:

- A. only two groups exist
- B. all groups have identical interests
- C. intermediate groups can retain status over groups below
- D. law abolishes all hierarchy

Answer: C. intermediate groups can retain status over groups below

Explanation: A ladder distributes an interest in distinction.

Trap/remediation: Avoid a simple binary model.

Q4. Which is an extreme practice of caste stigma?

- A. Varna
- B. Jati
- C. Occupation
- D. Untouchability

Answer: D. Untouchability

Explanation: Untouchability names intensified exclusion.

Trap/remediation: It is not a synonym for caste.

Q5. Universal franchise can democratically enable:

- A. representation and bargaining by subordinated groups

- B. automatic social equality
- C. the disappearance of caste
- D. only caste supremacy

Answer: A. representation and bargaining by subordinated groups

Explanation: Equal votes can create political voice.

Trap/remediation: Political equality is not social transformation.

Q6. Caste should be related to class and gender as:

- A. identical to both
- B. interacting but not reducible to either
- C. unrelated to either
- D. a biological category

Answer: B. interacting but not reducible to either

Explanation: Land, labour, gender and endogamy interact with caste.

Trap/remediation: Avoid reductionism.

Q7. A defensible assessment of caste political assertion is that it:

- A. is always anti-democratic
- B. is always emancipatory
- C. must be judged by programme and effect
- D. has no relation to equality

Answer: C. must be judged by programme and effect

Explanation: Assertion can seek equal voice or defend hierarchy.

Trap/remediation: Do not equate identity with supremacy.

Q8. Endogamy links caste and gender principally through:

- A. electoral voting
- B. taxation
- C. religious pluralism
- D. regulation of marriage and sexuality

Answer: D. regulation of marriage and sexuality

Explanation: Marriage closure reproduces caste membership.

Trap/remediation: Do not treat gender as an afterthought.

Q9. Gandhi's earlier idealised varna was presented as:

- A. hereditary duty without asserted superiority
- B. abolition of all birth allocation
- C. a defence of untouchability
- D. identical with jati

Answer: A. hereditary duty without asserted superiority

Explanation: This is why Gandhi must be periodised.

Trap/remediation: Do not erase the early liability.

Q10. The term 'Harijan' should be handled as:

- A. a neutral current self-description

- B. historical usage later rejected by many Dalit thinkers
- C. a constitutional category
- D. Ambedkar's preferred term

Answer: B. historical usage later rejected by many Dalit thinkers

Explanation: It requires a historical and contested-term note.

Trap/remediation: Do not present it as uncontested.

Q11. Gandhi's later trajectory became increasingly supportive of:

- A. separate electorates
- B. hereditary occupation
- C. inter-caste marriage and critique of birth barriers
- D. caste supremacy

Answer: C. inter-caste marriage and critique of birth barriers

Explanation: The owner requires a staged account.

Trap/remediation: Do not make Gandhi static.

Q12. The central theoretical liability of idealised hereditary varna is:

- A. it rejects all duty
- B. it abolishes work
- C. it guarantees equality
- D. birth allocation can preserve closure despite denied rank

Answer: D. birth allocation can preserve closure despite denied rank

Explanation: No declared superiority does not remove inherited assignment.

Trap/remediation: Rank and allocation are distinct issues.

Q13. For Gandhi, untouchability violates:

- A. truth, ahimsa and equal spiritual worth
- B. only electoral procedure
- C. economic calculation alone
- D. constitutional morality alone

Answer: A. truth, ahimsa and equal spiritual worth

Explanation: His argument is moral-religious.

Trap/remediation: Do not replace Gandhi's language with Ambedkar's.

Q14. Which best describes Gandhi's method?

- A. violent class conflict
- B. self-purification, satyagraha and constructive work
- C. reservation alone
- D. separate electorates alone

Answer: B. self-purification, satyagraha and constructive work

Explanation: His method joins moral and social practice.

Trap/remediation: Do not reduce it to private piety.

Q15. The structural objection to Gandhi is that:

- A. he opposed all reform

- B. law never matters
- C. heart-change can leave power and representation intact
- D. fraternity is irrelevant

Answer: C. heart-change can leave power and representation intact

Explanation: The objection concerns dependency on goodwill.

Trap/remediation: Do not caricature Gandhi.

Q16. A fair Gandhian reply to the structural objection is that:

- A. rights are unnecessary
- B. hierarchy is natural
- C. caste is only class
- D. constructive practice and moral responsibility change social relations

Answer: D. constructive practice and moral responsibility change social relations

Explanation: The reply is real but not complete.

Trap/remediation: Keep the residual need for safeguards.

Q17. In Ambedkar's account, endogamy is:

- A. a central mechanism of caste reproduction
- B. an irrelevant private choice
- C. a sufficient legal remedy
- D. a synonym for untouchability

Answer: A. a central mechanism of caste reproduction

Explanation: Closed marriage circles transmit group boundaries.

Trap/remediation: Do not call it the whole explanation.

Q18. Graded inequality means:

- A. equal ranks for all groups
- B. a hierarchy in which each level may be above some and below others
- C. economic class only
- D. a temporary electoral alliance

Answer: B. a hierarchy in which each level may be above some and below others

Explanation: It explains fractured solidarity.

Trap/remediation: Avoid binary language.

Q19. Caste is anti-social for Ambedkar because it:

- A. creates all cultural difference
- B. prevents voting
- C. institutionalises unequal status and restricted association
- D. requires no social sanction

Answer: C. institutionalises unequal status and restricted association

Explanation: Plurality differs from ranked separation.

Trap/remediation: Do not condemn diversity as such.

Q20. Castes in India is dated:

- A. 1932

- B. 1936
- C. 1956
- D. 1916

Answer: D. 1916

Explanation: The owner dates the endogamy analysis to 1916.

Trap/remediation: Do not confuse it with *Annihilation of Caste*.

Q21. Annihilation of Caste argues that:

- A. reforming practice while retaining sanction is insufficient
- B. untouchability alone is the issue
- C. inter-dining is always sufficient
- D. political rights are irrelevant

Answer: A. reforming practice while retaining sanction is insufficient

Explanation: The normative foundation and reproduction mechanisms must be confronted.

Trap/remediation: Do not make annihilation a slogan.

Q22. Which remedy most directly attacks endogamy?

- A. temple entry alone
- B. inter-caste marriage
- C. a single election
- D. a legal definition alone

Answer: B. inter-caste marriage

Explanation: Marriage across closed groups attacks reproduction of caste.

Trap/remediation: Do not treat it as the only remedy.

Q23. Education, organisation and self-respect are best understood as:

- A. individual charity
- B. a replacement for rights
- C. a politics of collective emancipation and voice
- D. proof that caste is over

Answer: C. a politics of collective emancipation and voice

Explanation: They build agency and representation.

Trap/remediation: Avoid self-help reduction.

Q24. Ambedkar's target in rejecting caste-sanctioning authority is:

- A. individual believers as such
- B. all freedom of conscience
- C. only economics
- D. authority used to impose hereditary civic inferiority

Answer: D. authority used to impose hereditary civic inferiority

Explanation: The claim is about social authority and equal citizenship.

Trap/remediation: Do not misstate it as hostility to persons.

Q25. For Ambedkar, fraternity is:

- A. the social basis that sustains liberty and equality

- B. a decorative feeling unrelated to democracy
- C. opposed to rights
- D. identical with charity

Answer: A. the social basis that sustains liberty and equality

Explanation: It makes equal associated living possible.

Trap/remediation: Do not sentimentalise it.

Q26. Constitutional morality chiefly requires:

- A. blind obedience to social custom
- B. placing civic equality above inherited social authority
- C. abolishing all institutions
- D. only periodic voting

Answer: B. placing civic equality above inherited social authority

Explanation: It restrains hierarchy through constitutional norms.

Trap/remediation: It is not automatic.

Q27. Ambedkar's conversion to Buddhism in the owner is dated:

- A. 1916
- B. 1932
- C. 1956
- D. 1990

Answer: C. 1956

Explanation: Conversion is ethical reconstruction around equality and fraternity.

Trap/remediation: Do not call it ritual change alone.

Q28. Which is NOT an adequate summary of Ambedkar?

- A. theorist of social democracy
- B. advocate of representation
- C. critic of graded inequality
- D. theorist of reservation alone

Answer: D. theorist of reservation alone

Explanation: Reservation is a safeguard in a wider programme.

Trap/remediation: Never reduce his doctrine to quotas.

Q29. The Poona Pact followed:

- A. the 1932 Communal Award's separate electoral arrangements
- B. the 1956 conversion
- C. the 1992 judgment
- D. the 2019 amendment

Answer: A. the 1932 Communal Award's separate electoral arrangements

Explanation: The Pact belongs to the representation dispute of 1932.

Trap/remediation: Do not detach event from issue.

Q30. The Poona Pact substituted separate electorates with:

- A. abolition of representation

- B. reserved seats in joint electorates with a primary-election mechanism
- C. universal adult franchise immediately
- D. a constitutional amendment

Answer: B. reserved seats in joint electorates with a primary-election mechanism

Explanation: It also increased reserved seats according to the owner.

Trap/remediation: Do not invent numbers.

Q31. Ambedkar's worry about joint electorates was that:

- A. religion would disappear
- B. all caste would end
- C. representatives could depend on dominant-caste votes
- D. law would become unnecessary

Answer: C. representatives could depend on dominant-caste votes

Explanation: The issue is autonomous political voice.

Trap/remediation: Do not narrate it as mere seat arithmetic.

Q32. A sound description of the Pact is:

- A. a harmonious consensus without pressure
- B. a dispute only about personalities
- C. proof Gandhi and Ambedkar agreed on caste
- D. a compromise reached in morally and politically coercive circumstances

Answer: D. a compromise reached in morally and politically coercive circumstances

Explanation: The context and autonomy issue must be retained.

Trap/remediation: Avoid celebratory narration.

Q33. Gandhi's secular-democratic emphasis is best captured by:

- A. equal regard, conscience and non-violence
- B. scriptural rank as civic law
- C. separate legal citizenship
- D. economic class alone

Answer: A. equal regard, conscience and non-violence

Explanation: This is distinct from Ambedkar's institutional test.

Trap/remediation: Do not collapse their foundations.

Q34. Ambedkar's secular-democratic test is:

- A. majority religious authority
- B. equal citizenship free from religiously sanctioned hierarchy
- C. absence of all ethics
- D. private charity

Answer: B. equal citizenship free from religiously sanctioned hierarchy

Explanation: No doctrine may make civic inferiority legitimate.

Trap/remediation: Do not make it merely state hostility to religion.

Q35. Article 17 is correctly described as:

- A. a judgment

- B. a commission report
- C. a constitutional rule abolishing untouchability
- D. proof discrimination disappeared

Answer: C. a constitutional rule abolishing untouchability

Explanation: Its existence does not establish social transformation.

Trap/remediation: Law and effect are distinct.

Q36. The SC/ST Prevention of Atrocities Act is:

- A. a constitutional amendment
- B. a commission report
- C. a judicial doctrine
- D. an enacted protective penal statute of 1989, in force in 1990

Answer: D. an enacted protective penal statute of 1989, in force in 1990

Explanation: Type and date matter.

Trap/remediation: Do not call it constitutional text.

Q37. A compensatory justification of affirmative action focuses on:

- A. rectifying transmitted group-directed exclusion
- B. rewarding guilt of every present individual
- C. abolishing merit
- D. religious conversion

Answer: A. rectifying transmitted group-directed exclusion

Explanation: The argument concerns continuing advantage/disadvantage, not personal guilt.

Trap/remediation: Use 'advantage, not guilt'.

Q38. A representational justification principally asks whether:

- A. past harm can never be repaired
- B. institutions include groups whose interests they govern
- C. everyone has identical income
- D. law replaces morality

Answer: B. institutions include groups whose interests they govern

Explanation: Presence and responsiveness concern democratic legitimacy.

Trap/remediation: Do not merge it with compensation.

Q39. The strongest merit-proxy reply says:

- A. merit has no value
- B. exams always measure capacity perfectly
- C. exam performance is a proxy affected by unequal access
- D. all outcomes should be identical

Answer: C. exam performance is a proxy affected by unequal access

Explanation: It contests the measurement of merit, not role competence.

Trap/remediation: Do not deny merit.

Q40. A genuine remaining concern about group remedies is:

- A. all historical harm is imaginary

- B. rights never matter
- C. representation automatically secures response
- D. over-inclusion and uneven incidence of cost

Answer: D. over-inclusion and uneven incidence of cost

Explanation: A strong answer concedes the residual design problem.

Trap/remediation: Do not pretend the objection vanishes.

Q41. The Mandal Commission is correctly classified as:

- A. a commission appointed in 1979 that reported in 1980
- B. a 1992 Supreme Court judgment
- C. a 2019 constitutional amendment
- D. a 1989 penal statute

Answer: A. a commission appointed in 1979 that reported in 1980

Explanation: A commission recommends; it does not enact.

Trap/remediation: Instrument type is examinable.

Q42. Indra Sawhney (1992) is:

- A. a statute
- B. a Supreme Court judgment on OBC reservation in central services under Article 16(4)
- C. a constitutional amendment
- D. a commission report

Answer: B. a Supreme Court judgment on OBC reservation in central services under Article 16(4)

Explanation: The owner also states creamy-layer exclusion and the ordinary 50-percent rule.

Trap/remediation: Do not extend its holding to later measures.

Q43. The 103rd Amendment (2019) is:

- A. a judgment
- B. a commission report
- C. an enabling amendment inserting Articles 15(6) and 16(6)
- D. a penal statute

Answer: C. an enabling amendment inserting Articles 15(6) and 16(6)

Explanation: It enables special provision, including up to ten percent for specified EWS categories.

Trap/remediation: Do not say it directly creates every reservation.

Q44. Janhit Abhiyan (2022) is identified in the owner as:

- A. a commission report
- B. a statute abolishing caste
- C. a constitutional amendment
- D. a Supreme Court judgment upholding the amendment by majority

Answer: D. a Supreme Court judgment upholding the amendment by majority

Explanation: It is a legal illustration, not philosophical proof.

Trap/remediation: Keep law and justification distinct.

Q45. Which final verdict best fits a Gandhi-Ambedkar comparison?

- A. Rights and structure are necessary; moral transformation must serve, not replace, them.

- B. Conscience alone guarantees equality.
- C. Law alone creates fraternity.
- D. The thinkers differed only in tone.

Answer: A. Rights and structure are necessary; moral transformation must serve, not replace, them.

Explanation: It preserves substantive disagreement while retaining a role for moral change.

Trap/remediation: Avoid false complementarity.

Q46. For a 20-marker comparison, the best organisation is:

- A. two biographies in sequence
- B. a common-axis grid followed by adjudication
- C. only legal provisions
- D. only a Poona Pact narrative

Answer: B. a common-axis grid followed by adjudication

Explanation: Shared axes make the philosophical difference visible.

Trap/remediation: Structure itself earns marks.

Q47. Which is the safest quotation discipline?

- A. Put all key terms in quotation marks.
- B. Attribute any memorable phrase without a source.
- C. Teach doctrines as doctrines unless a verified edition/page supports a quote.
- D. Invent exact dates for Gandhi's shifts.

Answer: C. Teach doctrines as doctrines unless a verified edition/page supports a quote.

Explanation: The owner is not a critical edition.

Trap/remediation: Do not fabricate quotations.

Q48. Which distinction closes a strong answer?

- A. Caste is only the past.
- B. All law is futile.
- C. Moral reform is irrelevant.
- D. Enactment, enforcement and social transformation are distinct stages.

Answer: D. Enactment, enforcement and social transformation are distinct stages.

Explanation: The conclusion links safeguards to unfinished social democracy.

Trap/remediation: Do not infer social change from a legal instrument.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

PYQ 1 - 2018 · Q1(c) (10 marks)

Question: It is said that the traditional hold of caste-based groups on Indian social behaviour has survived all attempts to build alternate identities. Discuss in the light of M. K. Gandhi.

Thesis / opening: Gandhi recognised that political freedom cannot replace reform of the everyday social relations through which caste persists.

Model answer structure:

- Periodise Gandhi: earlier idealised varna, anti-untouchability campaign, later greater criticism of birth barriers.
- Explain untouchability as a moral-religious wrong against truth and ahimsa.

- Use repentance, self-purification, constructive work and satyagraha as mechanisms of social reform.
- Qualify: inherited allocation and autonomous oppressed voice remain unresolved by conscience alone.

Conclusion: Gandhi explains why social conduct needs moral transformation, but lasting equal status also requires rights and autonomous representation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 2 - 2019 · Q4(a) (20 marks)

Question: Examine whether there is any difference between the views of Mahatma Gandhi and Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar on the philosophical foundations of secular democracy.

Thesis / opening: They share opposition to civic degradation but found secular democracy differently: Gandhi in equal religious regard and conscience, Ambedkar in equal citizenship against religiously sanctioned hierarchy.

Model answer structure:

- Compare target, root cause, reforming agent, method, religion, representation and democracy in parallel.
- Gandhi: non-violence, conscience, fellowship and reform from within.
- Ambedkar: constitutional morality, rights, representation and social democracy.
- Explain why no community doctrine may create civic inferiority.
- Give paternalism and legalism objections with replies, then a qualified verdict.

Conclusion: Gandhi supplies an ethic of coexistence; Ambedkar supplies the institutional test of equal civic standing.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 3 - 2020 · Q3(a) (20 marks)

Question: State and examine B.R. Ambedkar's contribution towards social changes in Independent India.

Thesis / opening: Ambedkar's contribution joins constitutional safeguards to a wider project of annihilating graded social status.

Model answer structure:

- Diagnose caste through endogamy, social closure and graded inequality.
- Explain rights, remedies, representation and constitutional morality as protections against social majorities.
- Develop liberty, equality and fraternity as social democracy.
- Add education, organisation, self-respect, conversion and economic independence.
- Use Article 17 as a constitutional illustration, not proof of completed social change.

Conclusion: His contribution is not reservation alone: it seeks a transformation from formal political equality to equal social standing.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 4 - 2021 · Q4(a) (20 marks)

Question: Discuss the views of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar regarding caste-discrimination in Indian society. What are the measures suggested by him for its elimination? Explain.

Thesis / opening: For Ambedkar, caste is graded inequality reproduced by endogamy, authority and power; eliminating untouchability alone therefore cannot suffice.

Model answer structure:

- Explain endogamy and division of labourers.
- Reconstruct annihilation: challenge caste-sanctioning authority and inter-caste marriage.
- Set out education, organisation, self-respect, rights and representation.
- Explain constitutional morality, fraternity and social democracy.

- Treat conversion as ethical-social reconstruction and state the limit of legal action.

Conclusion: The measures form an integrated programme of autonomous equality, not a list of welfare concessions.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 5 - 2022 · Q1(b) (10 marks)

Question: In the age of individualism and universal franchise, what role does caste play in body-politic? Discuss.

Thesis / opening: Universal franchise creates equal political status, but caste can still organise social power, representation and mobilisation.

Model answer structure:

- State the franchise/social-hierarchy distinction.
- Show representation and bargaining as democratic possibilities.
- Show candidate selection, patronage and social blocs as persistence mechanisms.
- Distinguish oppressed assertion from caste supremacy and give a qualified verdict.

Conclusion: Caste is politically ambivalent: it may voice historic exclusion yet cannot itself dissolve graded social status.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 6 - 2022 · Q2(b) (15 marks)

Question: Critically evaluate Gandhi's views on eradication of caste discrimination.

Thesis / opening: Gandhi's moral mobilisation against untouchability is indispensable, but reform dependent on dominant conscience is structurally insecure.

Model answer structure:

- Periodise varna, anti-untouchability and later movement.
- Explain ahimsa, repentance, satyagraha and constructive programme.
- Credit his mass moral intervention and privileged-caste responsibility.
- Assess paternalism, varna and structural-power objections with fair replies.
- Conclude that moral change must supplement enforceable equality and voice.

Conclusion: Gandhi remains ethically significant, but cannot substitute for the institutional transformation demanded by equal citizenship.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 7 - 2023 · Q3(b) (15 marks)

Question: Critically analyse the social and political significance of Ambedkar's notion of annihilation of caste.

Thesis / opening: Annihilation is socially significant because it makes fraternity and association possible, and politically significant because it makes representation and equal citizenship real.

Model answer structure:

- Trace caste sanction, endogamy and graded inequality.
- Explain why reform of untouchability alone leaves the foundation intact.
- Social significance: free association, inter-caste kinship and fraternity.
- Political significance: autonomous organisation, rights, representation and social democracy.
- Raise legalism/state-competence limits and reply through the wider programme.

Conclusion: The doctrine seeks abolition of hereditary valuation, not merely adjustment of access to offices.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 8 - 2024 · Q1(c) (10 marks)

Question: Discuss the main factors responsible for caste discrimination.

Thesis / opening: Caste discrimination is reproduced through mutually reinforcing marriage closure, inherited rank, occupational restriction, ritual sanction and power.

Model answer structure:

- Differentiate varna, jati, caste and untouchability.
- Explain endogamy, hereditary status and occupational closure.
- Add purity-pollution, religious sanction, economic dependence and social violence.
- Use graded inequality to explain durability and finish with a structural verdict.

Conclusion: The factors form a reproducing system; no single cultural or economic factor explains caste discrimination alone.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

PYQ 9 - 2025 · Q2(a) (20 marks)

Question: Present a detailed account of the debate between Gandhi and Ambedkar on the issue of caste discrimination.

Thesis / opening: Both condemn untouchability, but Gandhi principally seeks moral-religious reform while Ambedkar diagnoses caste itself as a structure requiring annihilation and autonomous power.

Model answer structure:

- Use the seven-axis comparison: target, varna/caste, root mechanism, agent, method, religion, democracy.
- Interpret Poona Pact as conflict over representative autonomy, not seat arithmetic.
- Contrast heart-change with rights and institutional power.
- Add secular democracy, constitutional morality and fraternity.
- Adjudicate paternalism and legalism, ending with a qualified structural verdict.

Conclusion: The strongest synthesis is Ambedkarite in rights and structure, while retaining moral transformation as a necessary but non-substituting condition.

Why this earns marks: It answers the exact demand through a clear claim, named doctrine or evidence, analysis, qualification and a direct concluding verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks · 150 words

Question: Explain why Ambedkar's distinction between a division of labour and a division of labourers is central to a philosophical account of caste discrimination.

Model solution:

- Claim: a functional allocation of tasks need not rank persons or fix them by birth.
- Named evidence: Ambedkar's caste diagnosis joins hereditary status, endogamy and social closure.
- Analysis: caste assigns occupation and worth to workers, restricts mobility and fractures association through graded inequality.
- Qualification: endogamy is central but must be paired with ritual authority and material power.
- Verdict: the distinction explains why abolition requires equal social standing, not merely occupational reform.

Original Mains 2 - 15 marks · 220 words

Question: Critically assess the claim that Gandhian moral reform and Ambedkarite constitutional safeguards are mutually necessary for the eradication of caste discrimination.

Model solution:

- Define the question as a non-substitution problem: moral change and enforceable equality do different work.

- Gandhi: anti-untouchability, repentance, constructive practice and the responsibility of privileged castes.
- Ambedkar: endogamy, graded inequality, representation, constitutional morality and social democracy.
- Objection to Gandhi: paternalism and powerlessness; reply: law cannot manufacture fellowship.
- Objection to Ambedkar: legalism; reply: his programme includes fraternity, education, organisation and conversion.
- Verdict: safeguards must be structurally prior, while moral reform is indispensable only as their social realisation.

Original Mains 3 - 20 marks · 300 words

Question: Does affirmative action answer Ambedkar's critique of caste, or only mitigate one consequence of it?

Discuss with reference to representation, merit and social democracy.

Model solution:

- Thesis: affirmative action is a necessary safeguard for access and representation, but it cannot by itself annihilate the valuation of persons that caste creates.
- Name four grounds: compensatory, distributive, representational and anti-domination; select representation plus anti-domination as the leading frame.
- Explain the reverse-discrimination objection fairly, then reply through unequal production of examination proxies and continuing advantage rather than personal guilt.
- Concede over-inclusion and uneven incidence; explain the philosophical purpose and cost of internal filters.
- Use one typed illustration-Article 17, *Indra Sawhney*, or the 103rd Amendment-without treating it as philosophical proof.
- Return to Ambedkar: endogamy, fraternity, constitutional morality, organisation and conversion exceed access to positions.
- Verdict: safeguards mitigate exclusion and redistribute power; social democracy requires the deeper transformation of inherited status.